

4.1 Staying In Touch



E-mail has become the killer app of the Internet

4.1.1 E-mail

Electronic mail has all but replaced most forms of written communication. When was the last time you received snail-mail from someone? Banks don't count!

Contrary to popular belief, e-mail was present before the Internet was created. In fact, the tools used for e-mail today were the building blocks of the Internet. E-mail moved from being just another application of a network to becoming the killer app of the ARPANET and later, the Internet. So how does e-mail work? Well, it's not rocket science, but a detailed explanation would require more than a chapter. In a nutshell, messages (mails) are exchanged between hosts using the Simple Mail Transfer Protocol (SMTP) with software such as Sendmail. Users download their messages (received mails) from servers, usually using either the POP or IMAP protocols.